

RENOWN

the world, its ages, and its fifteen peoples

The Hook

Four and a half thousand years ago the world fractured, shattering dynasties, overturning climates, forcing migrations, and it has been filling the silence with forgotten empires ever since.

However, these empires do not last. Walk the Draggath Wastes and you will cross the ruins of abandoned cities of once-great empires — foundations under the dust, a gate standing in open country with no wall left to hold, a road that leads to an empty place: every one of them was once a certain claim. Every one of them had a banner, an edict, a value and a name its people would have died for, and did.

Nobody remembers their name.

There are some who have been remembered. Not the largest, nor the richest, nor the most dominant; but the ones that did something the world could not forget. Draggath, whose name became the word for empire, for everlasting monarchy, and then the word for ruin. Vogen, who outmaneuvered the strong and left a gallows where his name once was. Karalius, who never fought his own battles yet decided many. These are not the great — they are the remembered. Yet, in a world this forgetful, the two have become the same thing.

That is what is on offer. Not conquest — conquest is common. Empires rise to their zenith and fall with the same certainty as the sunrise, and the wastes are full of the men who managed it. Not wealth; the wealthiest people alive cannot be named by anyone, hiding in the shadows. What is to be claimed is Renown: to be one of the few empires the world does not misplace.

Most empires are forgotten. Make yours renowned.

The Age of Darkness

The world of Renown, called Vaelohk, broke apart almost five thousand years ago, ending the Age of Darkness. With the end of an age came rampant storms that raised water, carved rock, and shifted climate and biome, causing great migration and upheaval.

Before it sat the longest-reigning empire in the world of old — a name so ancient that the land, the dynasty and the monarch all shared it: Draggath. Within its reach the empire's land turned to desert, badland and bleak highland, causing a Great Fracturing within its peoples. This turned a great society of valour and honour into a civil war amongst city-states, nomadic tribes and powerful warbands.

And so began the Age of Prowess.

Deep in the Coloured Mountains, an ancient people believing in the deity of plenty, Trusti, migrated east to an unknown land to escape a blight caused by the dark storms. For centuries the Trusti cooperated, learning and passing down ancient techniques each family generation, creating a lineage of craft. Over time these people developed beyond subsistence farming and created a society of crafters, traders and merchants, all working in the best interest of its community. Following the blight, an Age of Plenty had begun. The red soil left over from the blight raised Scarlet Forests that grew to the size of ancient trees within a generation, and with it came shipyards, migrations, trade and wealth. The peninsula of Blighthold became a beacon of affluence, which created much attention.

An ancient, sparsely populated, arid land of the south-western dunes was occupied only by the most cunning. These were the people of Clypso — a people of night. Living under the sands was hard rock, cut and chiselled into underground catacombs, buildings and customs-houses to sleep in and to avoid the dangerous heat of Clypso's Wrath: a legend of ancient history, the revenge of the demigod upon whom they cast doubt.

That is, until the great storms came and never stopped. First the wells overflowed. Then so did the tunnels. The Ithiss of Clypso left their sunken catacombs to find the landscape changing into a lush forest, and they began to settle above ground. But the Ithiss were untrusting, and soon began stealing from one another in the night, hiding into the forests to count their spoils. To survive, brotherhoods, guilds and syndicates formed, levying power to control the flow of goods in their territories, and with wanton disregard punishing those who attempted to steal from them.

Long ago, in the place now known as the Tomb of the Old Gods, was a pharisaical people, arrogant, legalistic, and vain. The Essels had built a civilisation of worship and adoration, sculpting, carving, and erecting the world's tallest and grandest cathedrals and basilicas.

Over time, the Essels' vanity grew, and with it came its laxity. Eventually, the gods of old disappeared from the lips of its Pharisees, and in response, their names became sacrilege to merely

mention, fearing the penance of their acknowledgment.

As the storms rose over the mountains, the civilisation once pious left their golden cities as ash fell from the sky. These people migrated across the sea of ash into the boxed mountains of Lenaveron, where the Lenavorites issued their first record — the name of its home.

The Lenavorites, over time, began to focus their efforts on history, record keeping, and the formation of the Truth. Soon, new gods were born: Ollanenor, the god of Saints; Lorenthai, the god of Peace; Melvanar, the god of Wrath; and Anumaranth, the god of Balance.

For each god existed an Order that rose to fill the void caused by the migrations and lack of purpose.

Ollanenor was run by the Order of Saints, the first order, used to determine a priest's Saint's name — the name they took, foregoing their old identity, to take on the work of that Saint as their own. The Inquisition, a growing arm of the order, trains the populace of Lenaveron preparing for their Saint's name, removing all pharisaic tendencies from its own people to prevent the next fall, always suspicious of its imminent arrival.

The Order of Mission represents Lorenthai, and is responsible for the mission work of expanding its name and authority across all borders.

The Order of Penance of Melvanar prepares its people and all inhabitants of Vaelohk for the return of Melvanar, seeking justice against those who had fallen from his path.

Lastly, from Anumaranth came the Order of the True Word. They were strict record keepers, fact finders, and administrators. In order to fund the grand instrument of the papacy, the Tithe was implemented, causing all under the reach of the four gods, the Tetramorph, to tithe in order to fund and fuel the great power of Lenaveron.

The Overview

What The World Is Made Of

Trusteki

Industry

The Trusteki settled in what is now known as Blighthold. During the great famine the Trusti fled the Coloured Mountains and settled, focusing their efforts on evolving their techniques, seeking mastery of their pursuits, and adapting to the changing climate of the Blight. From that blight red trees emerged from diseased, red soil, growing to the size of Old Wood in a fraction of the time. The Trusteki continued to refine their craft, passing their knowledge each generation down the family tree. They formed democratic republics, built infrastructure, and elected those who served the interests of their people. They created large shipyards and supply lines, connecting their craft to the world for an honest price. This wealth and abundance created opportunity for those less dependent on moral quandaries.

Ithiss

Cunning

The Ithiss have long survived as a people in the Dreadwoods, originally living in underground cities before the Dreadwoods grew. The people of the underground cities rejected the god Clypso, who in return planted a seed of doubt that would never be unsown. A vicious aristocracy ensues in an otherwise lawless land, neighbouring guilds and brotherhoods destabilising their opponents and razing settlements of those who are too powerful. The Ithiss may not create supply lines or fight for glory, but they strike fear and alter the way of life for their neighbours. The Ithiss do what serves their interest, especially when it hurts others.

Prezish

Cunning / Industry

Some who fled that way of life found opportunity in trade, fencing stolen goods, or brokering deals in back rooms — they are the Prezish. They roamed north into the Marrow Shoals, working with migrating Trusteki, helping them navigate the waters, for a steep price in gold or an idle threat of being thrown overboard. The Prezish grew an ecosystem that controlled trade routes, set prices, and cornered markets. Many become pirates who profit from deception, threat of force, sabotage, and blackmail. A Prezish is always interested in a negotiation — of course, if it fails, they will interdict. Nothing crosses the waters without them knowing, or taking a cut.

Voldrastel

Piety / Industry / Prowess

To the far north-west, across the centre isle, lies an archipelago — the Twelfth Reach, held by the Voldrastel. A people founded on the ideals of fairness and justice, they are wardens of the seas and of the indefensible, promoting peace and stability by any means necessary. To travel the seas under the safety of the Voldrastel comes at a price. One must pay tolls, or hire them to transport cargo, as they out-manoeuvre the Drakteni, interdict the Prezish, assist the Madekites, and shield the Trusteki. They generate gold without production. Their value is their presence.

The Faith, And Its Breaking

Lenavorites

Piety

In the corner to the far east lie the Tombs of the Old Gods: vast ancient ruins of gothic basilicas and beautiful monuments to gods whose names have long been forgotten. From that cultural hearth these people dispersed — north into the Lost Woods, south into the deeper tundra to find Fair Whitewood, west across the Strait of Sorrow, or into the mountains, where the first record ever set down in all of Vaelohk was its name: Lenaveron. The Lenavorites are a self-flagellating, unforgiving people, eager to regain their lost devotion, seeking piety through any means. Tithe. Spread the gospel. Offer yourself as a missionary, or a martyr. And most importantly: record it. From the Lenavorites came a large papal institution of administration. The Inquisition of Ollanenor taught the way of life and assigned your role in it by assigning your name according to a saint, forgoing all prior sense of self.

Madekites

Piety / Industry

Other pious fled into the frozen forest of Fair Whitewood, rich with tundra and forestry, during the fall of the old gods. They sought to redeem themselves, labouring to prove their devotion, suffering as a form of worship — all of it serving to reconstruct the wonders of the old gods, seeking perfection from stone and the ancient techniques used to raise cathedrals and citadels that insulate them from all foreign influence, reach, and affront. They build defence from devotion, in the desolate frozen tundra, chasing a vain perfection.

Belvareth

Piety / Prowess

South of the Draggath Wastes lie the Bleak Highlands, rough terrain suitable for smaller warbands who pledge fealty to larger ones. The most determined Kraghs, who sought glory and rich land, marched south to the Wheat Fields — a place once known for its fertile soil, now a perpetual battlefield in an attempt to lay claim to the Lost Woods, which are fervently protected by the Belvareth, the Order of the Preceptory of Melvanar. The Lost Woods are hallowed ground to those who are pious, and the Belvareth were formed by the most devout of the old gods and the Kraghs who sought a new way of life. Together they pair, in order to train in body and spirit and defend this sacred site from all outsiders of any kind.

Shassolin

Cunning / Piety

Others moved east out of the Dreadwood, finding marsh and pious people seeking refuge, whose journey named the Strait of Sorrow. The Shassolin found religion in its despondency. They formed a new order — one of a new prophet, the Last Prophet, capable of speaking to the God of Gods himself, knowing and uttering its name, Esselantheum, and carrying messages directly to him. Missionary work is perpetual, seeking more to convert, to tithe, and to offer indulgences for their lack of faith. Unfortunately, it never seems to be enough.

The War That Did Not End

Kraghs

Prowess

In the Draggath Wastes there once stood an empire whose monarch reigned as the longest and largest dynasty in all of Vaelohk. Then a great famine swept Draggath, and a great fracturing occurred, and the empire turned into civil war — each city-state and warband fighting over shrinking tillable, fertile soil. From that civil war arose the Kraghs, a people of prowess. They rule as iron-fisted leaders, treasuring martial training and strength above all else, settling disputes by battle, eager to prove themselves against their neighbouring counterparts. Plunder and vassals lie waiting for those who succeed in the ruins of the Draggath Wastes — an ancient empire's remains scattered across desolate, sandy soil.

Vorghith

Prowess / Cunning

Many Ithiss of the Dreadwood, shipwrecked or imprisoned, found venture in a world where fighting in the open was expected — glory prioritised. From the shadows the Vorghith rose the night, attacking the Kraghs in their sleep and behind their front lines, causing fear and disrupting the supply lines of those who cross them. The Kraghs, never knowing friend from foe, retreated from the prison fortress and bay. From there a wave of terror spread: raiding settlements in the night, burning crops and granaries, razing infrastructure, and capturing neighbouring leaders to execute them in the prison's square — Vogen's Gallows. The Vorghith refuse a fair fight and evade any sustained skirmish, always retreating into the towns they will strike that night.

Drakteni

Prowess / Industry

West of the Wastes, Trusteki who had run from the disease-ridden peninsula of Blighthold found Kraghs escaping the war-torn desolation of the wasteland behind them. Together they settled a small continent rich with mines, erecting siege works and blast furnaces to construct equipment of war, eager to expand their territory. The youngest of cultures, these people focused — erecting a martial hierarchy, building armaments, siege craft and professional soldiery into a way of life. The expansion of their territory grew into their greatest edict, laying campaigns against the Kraghs in Hermit's Row and besieging the Madekites in the frozen, desolate cathedral fortresses of Fair Whitewood.

Cailendroffs

Piety / Prowess / Cunning

Close by in the isles, the Cailendroffs have been exiled since the Great Fracture, over four thousand years ago, long scheming the return of their monarch to the Draggath throne — whom they believe is the last surviving bloodline of the oldest dynasty. The Cailendroffs believe they are direct descendants of the Warrior-Prophet Cailen, one of the old gods, who chose Draggath as Emperor. These people believe they are the last true way to unite the Kraghs, and are preparing their armies for crusade, converting as many as they can to reinstate the Scion of Draggath over the Water.

Sarkopekt

Cunning / Industry / Prowess

Off the coast of Lenaveron, the Wharf of St. Brannoch operates as a natural sanctuary, allowing a merchant class of city-states, warbands, and travelling nomads to work as freelancers and arms-dealers, with small nodes in every corner of the world — from the Bay of Lost Hope to the shores of the Bleak Highlands. These people are known as the Sarkopekt. Run by merchant kings and border princes, striking deals of protection, a supply of arms, or hired freelancers as a standing army, living in the moral ambiguities of others' objectives and desires, for a steep price. These people will tear wealth from flesh, given the chance.

The Centre

Astravantheliad

Piety / Prowess / Cunning / Industry

In the centre lies a large isle, Vaelohk, home to those who travelled through the Sea of Drakes, survived the doldrums of the Lonely Sea, and saw miracles on the Sea of Miracles. From there the Astravantheliad rose, embracing all knowledge, generalising in all works and walks of life, continuously researching and seeking mastery in life. With this came great influence, which was harnessed by the Duke — whose authority is granted by the Astravantheliad as a neutral arbiter to all cultures.

Ossensteins

Cunning / Piety / Industry

In the shadows of every important Academic Hall, administrative building, and public forum, the Ossensteins are rumoured to exist. It is believed they own more than half the wealth in all of Vaelohk, and that they are the handlers of the False Prophet — creating disasters and catastrophes to profit and to influence.

The World

WIP → One sea, and no name for the whole of it. Each shore names the water it can see, and the ring is wide enough that they are all describing something different.

The Land

Prowess — NE

Draggath Wastes

WIP → Once the Great Monarchy that held the whole continent; the Great Fracture shattered it into warring city-states. Named for the final monarch — and for the empire, the dynasty, and the land, all synonymous. Fertile once: endless war (salted earth, deforestation) made it badlands, and the ruins are the former bounty. Recursive scarcity — the more they fought over the lessening fertile land, the less there was.

Bleak Highlands

WIP → Pastoralists, living as historical Highlanders did — herding clans under a chief they swear fealty to. The northern limit of Vorghith expansion: Vogen, their general, drove up to here in 1136 and no further. Also a Sarkopekt free-company node. When the Pincer was organised it was Highland clans who enlisted in the Mason-King's mercenary company in exchange for his services — paying in fealty-service rather than coin, which is how their oaths already work.

Glen of Pravak

WIP → Named for the warband of Pravak — the most well-trained Kragh warband of the early Fracture, which held the last remaining glen of tillable land for centuries. Their strong internal pact disallowed Vorghith infiltration: the one known counter to the problem that would later cost the Kraghs the bay, solved in one glen and never generalised. Their dual concentration on athleticism and strategy, plus intimate knowledge of the ground, let them posture every battle in the glen into their favour. Pravak is long gone, but his attention to positional strategy and tactics reshaped how the Kraghs train.

Cravencroft

WIP → The Kraghs hold that giants here destroy the weak and the outcast. A threat aimed at their own: giants that eat the weak is the story a glory-or-death culture tells to keep weakness from taking root. Nobody volunteers to test it.

Hermit's Row

WIP → A narrow pair of mountain ranges. The Drakteni hold a position and settlement here; the Kraghs hold the narrows against them.

Vogen's Gallows

WIP → Named for Vogen, the Vorghith general whose signature was assassinating opponents by public execution. The best prison-turned-fortress and island bay on the continent — abandoned by the Kraghs when they could no longer tell who among them was Vorghith, and inherited by the prisoners. Public execution is psychological and economic warfare, not battlefield glory: a Kragh kills you in open combat for honour, Vogen hangs you in the square so everyone watches.

Industry — NW

Blighthold

WIP → Castle in the mountains. The heath where the Trusteki grew crops through the Blight using ancient trade secrets, working together to survive the diseased land. Named for what it endured — and it doubles as reverse-marketing to keep people from coming. Received the migration from the Coloured Mountains at the opening of the Age of Plenty.

Scarlet Forest

WIP → The soil south of Blighthold turned blood red after the Blight, and Scarlet trees grew from it — a verdant swelling, trees reaching the size of the old wood of Fair Whitewood within a single generation. Produces the best wood in the world. The most damaged land became the most valuable, and they would never fight the earth again.

Coloured Mountains

WIP → The ancient continent where the Trusteki first formed as farmers worshipping the old deity Trusti. Their migration to Blighthold opens the Age of Plenty.

Heathport

WIP → A natural port with plentiful mines, found by Trusteki who built ships and fled east after the Blight — where they met Prowess and became the Drakteni. Now one end of the Ithiss-to-Prezish illicit route (Heathport to the Wharf of St. Brannoch).

Drakenheart

WIP → Drakteni seat. Their craft is conquest: firepower built to expand beyond the continent, campaigns constantly funded and refunded. It is also the smallest landmass for the size of the culture on it — the engine of everything they do. They colonise to make room for themselves as an empire.

Cunning — SW

Dreadwood

WIP → Ithiss heartland. An anarchic aristocracy of brotherhoods and guilds forming criminal empires — no central authority, but a rigid internal hierarchy of the feared and successful.

Crag Pass

WIP → A natural chokepoint of narrow paths, labyrinths, and slot canyons, found and controlled by the Ithiss from their underground network — reached in secret, held without garrison. Where Trusteki caravans learned the dangers of the south, and the route by which Ithiss who wanted another life ventured north.

Marrow Shoals

WIP → Shared water — Ithiss and Prezish both. Where Trusteki venturing south met the Ithiss coming north, forming the Prezish.

Bay of Pigs

WIP → A weaponized false exonym. The dismissive name was given by outsiders, and the locals keep it deliberately — a bay named for filth attracts no attention and lowers a merchant's guard. Prezish seat: pirates, smugglers, brokers, money-lenders and profiteers. The name is the first move of the con.

Piety — S/SE

Lenaveron

WIP → Named by the Lenavorites after themselves when they migrated north and west out of the frozen tundra — the first written record in the world. Papacy heartland; seat of the Papal Palace (Anumaranth) and the Inquisitorial Palace (Ollanenor).

Lost Woods

WIP → Sacred to the crusader order. Pilgrims come to 'meet the God of Gods' — and the Belvareth cut them down; the meeting is death. Theologically correct from inside: seeking Esselantheum directly is the blasphemy, and Melvanar's doctrine spreads by the reduction of false gods. Everyone sincere, nobody lying. The only land left untouched by the Great Fracture.

Wheat Fields

WIP → Not a border — a proving ground. The strongest warbands and warlords come here on purpose to test themselves against the Belvareth, known as the best warriors in the world; some believe they truly are their god's wrath made manifest. A frontier under conquest-pressure would fall or expand; a proving ground stays exactly where it is forever, because both sides want it to. Never paved: hallowed ground, where the world comes to be measured. Men reaped like wheat.

Tombs of the Old Gods

WIP → The frozen south-eastern tundra the Lenavorites abandoned. Site of the Great Basilica — an old-wonder of the vanished high civilization. The graveyards and basilicas were left to crumble and the old gods forgotten: abandoned institutions, not dead beings. The Madekites chase the lost technology of the Basilica still.

Fair Whitewood

WIP → Wintery forested mountain pass. Settled by Trusteki who moved north 'seeking religion' and became the Madekites — hard tundra rich with quarries, where the pain and sacrifice of building is devotion. Their fortress-cathedrals exist because the expansionist Drakteni will not stop coming.

Strait of Sorrow

WIP → Named by the Lenavorites who built simple rafts and fled west after the Fracture — many and most fell ill on the journey and died, only to find a worse swampy wetland to settle, inhabited by bandits and conmen of the immoral kind.

Shallow Mire / Quiet Hollow

WIP → Swampy wetland at the end of the Strait of Sorrow. Shassolin territory — administrators and missionaries of the false religion, stranded frontier clergy abandoned and repurposed.

Wharf of St. Brannoch

WIP → Named for a saint. A natural sanctuary off the coast of Lenaveron, and the busiest of the Sarkopekt nodes — where city-states, warbands and travelling nomads hire themselves out. Also the far end of the Ithiss-to-Prezish illicit route from Heathport.

The Sea, and the Isles

The Lonely Sea

WIP → A vast open sea of doldrums.

The Sea of Drakes

WIP → Tumultuous. Mythology holds that flying drakes destroy ships to protect it. Borders the Prowess corner.

The Sea of Miracles

WIP → Where miracles are said to have happened.

The Sea of Damnation

WIP → Fraught with Drakteni and Sarkopekt — where the damned are sent to meet their deserved fate. The name is honest by accident: what is actually out there is a conquest fleet and mercenary free companies of unknown allegiance. Whether the damnation is theological or just Drakteni siege-ships depends on who you ask.

Vaelohk

WIP → The centre island, and the world's name. Grounded and educated: home to the Academic Halls, the technocratic senate, and the Duke. Place-names here are plain common-tongue (The Duchy's Mouth, Bay of Renown).

Ivory Isle

WIP → Known historically as the seat of Mason-King Karalius II — shipwright and builder of masonry citadels, the expensive solution that always worked. His wealth was recognised, not self-styled. Now a Sarkopekt node sitting between the seat of power and the war-market.

Dead Waters

WIP → Named for what came out of the shipyard raised on its then-unnamed shore. The Pincer folded the Belvareth here — the only defeat ever recorded of them.

Sea of Ash

WIP → A sea completely contaminated by Ash. Crossable, but it yields nothing — no fish, no drinking water. You carry everything across it or you do not arrive. Some say it is the ash of the old gods.

Prophet's Landing

WIP → A beautiful tropical archipelago — paradise as bait. Where the false god manifested among the excommunicated (expelled for failing to recognise the Tetramorph). The only place in the world where Esselantheum is spoken aloud; saying it is the sales pitch.

The Twelfth Reach

WIP → Twelve islands. A diaspora zone receiving displaced Prowess x Industry peoples, governed by the Voldrastel — neutral wardens of the trade routes, safe passage and honest brokering for a toll and a broker's fee.

Cailendroff Isles

WIP → Home of the exiled pretender's people, driven out during the Great Fracture and never possessing the means to return — the harder now with Sarkopekt free companies patrolling the Sea of Damnation under unknown allegiance.

Bay of Lost Hope

WIP → A Sarkopekt free-company node.

The Reckoning

Year 0 = The Great Fracture.

Year 0

The Great Fracture

0	WIP → The Draggath Empire suddenly collapsed. A great storm came, changing the geography of the entire world over the course of several generations. North-west: disease and blight. South-west: a bountiful land — tall forests, tropical islands teeming with plenty. South-east: mire, a faint reminder of the land of the old gods. North-east: desolate wasteland, crumbling the Empire's reach into civil war over the last dying flora and fertile soil
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The Age of Fracture

0–1352

0	WIP → The Great Fracture. Draggath falls
0–~400	WIP → Geography transforms over several generations. Lenavorites build simple rafts and flee west — naming the Strait of Sorrow, as many and most fell ill on the journey and died, only to find a worse swampy wetland to settle, inhabited by bandits and conmen of the immoral kind WIP → The Ithiss leave their underground cities as the climate changes
0–1352	WIP → The civil war — the primary motif of the timeline, but not the only thing happening. Recursive scarcity: the more they fought over the lessening fertile land, the less fertile land there was to fight over, and the more they had to fight to claim it. Trusteki and Lenavorites migrate throughout WIP → The Trusteki endure the Blight, using ancient trade secrets to grow crops in the heath of what was soon dubbed Blighthold, working together to survive the diseased land

The Age of Plenty

1352–1942

1352	WIP → From the proliferation of the Scarlet Forest, the migration to Blighthold from the Coloured Mountains, and the general capacity to move at sea WIP → The soil south of Blighthold turns blood red; Scarlet trees grow from it. A verdant swelling — trees reaching the size of the old wood of Fair Whitewood within a single generation. The Trusteki's skill lets them survive and repel the blight
1352–1942	WIP → The migrations. Some Trusteki, not stalwart, move north seeking religion in the wintery forested mountain pass of Fair Whitewood. Others build ships and flee east, finding a natural port dubbed Heathport with plentiful mines. Others venture south to the archipelago of the Marrow Shoals, meeting the fleeing Ithiss coming from the south, seeking another way of life WIP → The utopia. Survival and cooperative spirit propel the Trusteki into a great utopia — far from perfect. Wealth eventually outpaces meaning; criminality and indulgence follow

The Age of the Tetramorph

1942–3066

1942	WIP → Lenavorites are scattered in tiny abbeys, priories and monasteries, forming many small orders. These begin combining into larger and larger administrative bodies in the search of truth. Rises as a response to the excess and over-indulgence of the Industrial utopia
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1942–2100	WIP → The unifying force. The four gods are recorded — Ollanenor, Anumaranth, Melvanar, Lorenthel. The papacy begins at this moment. Mission work starts as a collective movement WIP → The Inquisition appears — mostly idle and symbolic. As proof of the absence of any other false gods, they do nothing
2100–3066	WIP → Peak reach. Missions carry the faith to the furthest shores, and the bureaucracy doubles, and doubles again

The Age of Doubt

3066–4516

3066	WIP → Consolidating the small orders into one papacy required declaring who stood outside it. Excommunications for failing to recognize the Tetramorph — and the excommunicated go somewhere WIP → The false god manifests on Prophet's Landing, among the excommunicated. A schism of distance as much as doctrine — out past where the papacy's reach ended. By the time the center noticed, it was an institution
3100–4516	WIP → The Inquisition seizes government. It began as a response to stifle the False Prophet. The papacy is reduced to collection and administration — Anumaranth's Order of the True Word still records everything and rules nothing. The Inquisition rules. The religion turns gothic horror: a timeline of hysteria and control WIP → The paranoia engine. The Inquisition keeps growing and preys on its own people, ever more suspicious that the Lenavorites themselves are converting to the False Prophet. The threat is unfalsifiable (conversion is internal), so the work can never conclude. Suspicion → confession → proof → more suspicion. Worse: every purge exiles converts to Prophet's Landing, manufacturing the thing it fears. Free recruitment for the false church, funded by the orthodoxy's own fear WIP → The Ossensteins — little-known until now — fund and propel the False Prophet's word, as a matter of profit and of control over their own people. A cartel that invented a church to keep its workforce obedient
3300–4516	WIP → The edges break off. The papacy's administration crumbles under its own size — not completely, but the frontier shears away. Distant dioceses stop answering. The Shassolin were not infiltrators: they were church administrators and missionaries on the frontier when the connection to the center failed — abandoned and repurposed. Criminals and Machiavellians climb the cracks into aristocratic power. The papacy knows and denies WIP → The reign of the puppetmasters. Raiders and piracy flourish in ungoverned water. Chaos as decentralization, not apocalypse

The Age of Renown

4516–present

4516	WIP → The return to power. Stable tension after the dramatic ages — a perfect balance of power and everyone's motivations within it. (The start date is contested: the Astravantheliad argue it began earlier; the True Word insists on the recorded year, and revising it would be blasphemy.)
~4570s–4580s	WIP → The present day. A generation or two into the Age

What The World Is Made Of

Trusteki

Pure · Industry · Blighthold

Government	Democracy
Authority	Consent / competence
Sacred	The work / building / order (Peace) deified, or atheist
Organisation	Craft
Economy	Production, craft, trade
Kinship	The bloodline (inheritance)
Identity	You are your inheritance
Succession	Vote / merit
Change	Future (progress)
War doctrine	Tech, logistics, siege
Taboo	Waste / idleness
Defined against	The wasteful
Naming	[name] [craft-surname] [numeral]
Monuments	Manor House, Office of Works

The Trusteki settled in what is now known as Blighthold. During the great famine the Trusti fled the Coloured Mountains and settled, focusing their efforts on evolving their techniques, seeking mastery of their pursuits, and adapting to the changing climate of the Blight. From that blight red trees emerged from diseased, red soil, growing to the size of Old Wood in a fraction of the time. The Trusteki continued to refine their craft, passing their knowledge each generation down the family tree. They formed democratic republics, built infrastructure, and elected those who served the interests of their people. They created large shipyards and supply lines, connecting their craft to the world for an honest price. This wealth and abundance created opportunity for those less dependent on moral quandaries.

Trade

WIP → The primary traders and suppliers of the world. This is what keeps them functioning with no martial might and relatively stable: they are indispensable. You do not raid the people who supply you. Their safety is economic, not military — wealthy and powerful while focused on the craft, outputting to whoever is willing to purchase. They are the honest base layer every other trade culture acts upon: the Prezish corner it, the Voldrastel guard it, the Vorghith strangle it, the Ithiss fence through it, the Sarkopekt sell arms alongside it.

Internal conflict

WIP → Almost none. Families producing and competing in the same craft are judged by the market, not by each other — competition is externalised onto an impartial arbiter, so there is no advantage to seize by scheming. The familial trade and craft dynasties are so old that the market is legible: everyone understands what it needs, families step in to fill the gaps, and it is all respected by other Trusteki. No Cunning here. The structural anti-Ithiss: both

lack a central authority, but Cunning turns that into predation and Industry turns it into a guild. It is also why the Ossensteins had to leave — you cannot be a puppetmaster among people who will not play the game.

Relations

Lenavorites — mixed with — The Tithe against the papal contract — the same hand taxes and buys.

Sarkopekt — ally — Lumber for safe passage - trade at the Bay of Lost Hope.

Ithiss — wary of — Fearful of the syndicates that bleed their profits.

Vorghith — preys on them — Stolen ships against the trade routes - the sea raid on the market's lifelines.

Madekites — supplies them — Most of the masonry skill and supply for the Trusteki.

Kraghs — depends on them — They cannot feed or move themselves - reliant on Trusteki supply lines.

Holdings

Blighthold, Scarlet Forest, Coloured Mountains.

Ithiss

Pure · Cunning · Dreadwood + Marrow Shoals

Government	Aristocracy
Authority	Blood / leverage
Sacred	The game / process itself — addicted to the play; sabotage, theft, deception, blackmail are the sacraments. The False Prophet is a weaponized tool, not worshipped
Organisation	Brotherhood (a.k.a. Syndicate)
Economy	Extraction, racket, theft
Kinship	The brotherhood (hidden kin)
Identity	You are what you've done (concealed)
Succession	Blood / intrigue
Change	Opportunistic (cyclical)
War doctrine	Ambush, asymmetric, sabotage
Taboo	Trust / being known
Defined against	The honest
Naming	[name] [earned byname]
Monuments	Outlaw Rookery, Thieves' Guild, Outrider Intercept Post, Aristocratic Court

The Ithiss have long survived as a people in the Dreadwoods, originally living in underground cities before the Dreadwoods grew. The people of the underground cities rejected the god Clypso, who in return planted a seed of doubt that would never be unsown. A vicious aristocracy ensues in an otherwise lawless land, neighbouring guilds and brotherhoods destabilising their opponents and razing settlements of those who are too powerful. The Ithiss may not create supply lines or fight for glory, but they strike fear and alter the way of life for their neighbours. The Ithiss do what serves their interest, especially when it hurts others.

Trade

WIP → Primary supplier of illegally sourced fenced goods to the Prezish, who take them to market. Unscrupulous and conniving, willing to step over anyone, moving stolen and illicit goods from Heathport to the Wharf of St. Brannoch.

Relations

Shassolin — **preys on** — Working the Shassolin's serfs — robbery, caravans, rebellion.

Prezish — **supplies** — The fenced-goods pipeline — illicit source to the market-hand.

Trusteki — **preys on** — The primary prey — Trusteki caravans, first met at Crag Pass.

Lenavorites — **seeks to convert them** — The Inquisition seeks to leash the anarchy through religion.

Holdings

Dreadwood, Crag Pass.

Prezish

Pair · Cunning / Industry · Bay of Pigs / Marrow Shoals

Government	Oligarchic cartel — a guild-syndicate board
Authority	Leverage + competence — you rule by controlling supply
Sacred	The work + the game — the deal itself
Organisation	Syndicate-Guild (a trade cartel)
Economy	Production + racket — market manipulation, cornering supply, price-setting
Kinship	Merchant bloodlines bound into a syndicate
Identity	You are your inheritance and your leverage from it
Succession	Inherit a seat but must earn it — how much do you enrich the syndicate
Change	Future/opportunistic — whatever moves markets
War doctrine	Sabotage + logistics — economic weapons, embargo, bought force
Taboo	Waste + being cut out of the deal
Defined against	The wasteful and the honest
Naming	[name] [craft-surname] [numeral] — the 'craft' is trade; merchant dynasties
Monuments	Aristocratic Court, Thieves' Guild

Some who fled that way of life found opportunity in trade, fencing stolen goods, or brokering deals in back rooms — they are the Prezish. They roamed north into the Marrow Shoals, working with migrating Trusteki, helping them navigate the waters, for a steep price in gold or an idle threat of being thrown overboard. The Prezish grew an ecosystem that controlled trade routes, set prices, and cornered markets. Many become pirates who profit from deception, threat of force, sabotage, and blackmail. A Prezish is always interested in a negotiation — of course, if it fails, they will interdict. Nothing crosses the waters without them knowing, or taking a cut.

Relations

Sarkopekt — ally — The arms market — Prezish supply lines and brokered deals.

Ithiss — patron of — A wonderful arrangement - pay a pittance, charge a fortune.

Voldrastel — rival of — The trade routes — predator vs protector.

Astravantheliad — patron of them — The rare-goods pipeline — the collector at the clean end of a dirty chain.

Ossensteins — controls them — Rumoured to manage the Prezish trade and brokering.

Holdings

Bay of Pigs, Marrow Shoals.

Voldrastel

Triple · Piety / Industry / Prowess · The Twelfth Reach (12 islands)

Government	A council-republic of guardians under a code of moral faith
Authority	Divine mandate + competence + defensive force — trusted because principled
Sacred	The God of Gods + the work — faith and honest trade as duty
Organisation	A defensive order-guild (faithful merchant-wardens)
Economy	Production + tithe + tolls — they keep the routes open and take a fair share
Kinship	The order + trade-bloodlines + the defensive regiment
Identity	You give the self up to the duty of keeping the routes fair
Succession	Merit + chosen vessel — the trusted, tested guardian
Change	Tradition + progress — steady stewardship, improving safety
War doctrine	Defensive — convoy escort, fortified waystations, siege-resistant
Taboo	Waste + betrayal of trust + cowardice (abandoning a convoy)
Defined against	Raiders and cheats — those who prey on trade (esp. The Vorghith)
Naming	[name] [numeral] of the [order-fleet] — no saint's name as their humility doesn't allow themselves to be compared to saints
Monuments	Ministry of Military Strategy, Advanced Blast Furnace, Preceptory of the Knight's Templar

To the far north-west, across the centre isle, lies an archipelago — the Twelfth Reach, held by the Voldrastel. A people founded on the ideals of fairness and justice, they are wardens of the seas and of the indefensible, promoting peace and stability by any means necessary. To travel the seas under the safety of the Voldrastel comes at a price. One must pay tolls, or hire them to transport cargo, as they out-manoeuvre the Drakteni, interdict the Prezish, assist the Madekites, and shield the Trusteki. They generate gold without production. Their value is their presence.

Role

WIP → Neutral defenders of the trade routes and seas — safe passage and honest brokering as an intermediary, for a toll and a broker's fee. The stoic wardens of the world's roads and sea routes: powerful, and wielded for good.

Doctrine

WIP → The carry trade. Model: the Dutch Republic fused with 18th-century Britain. From the Dutch — a merchant-republic governed by the trading class itself, wealth from the entrepot (facilitating flow, not owning production), financial instruments, defensive survival by being too costly to take and too useful to destroy, and tolerance as commercial policy. From Britain — balance-of-power doctrine, naval command of the routes, coalition-shifting to prevent any hegemon, and a virtue that happens to be profitable. In a world of fifteen cultures fighting over what they can hold, the Voldrastel win by holding nothing and moving everything.

Strategy

WIP → Status-quo enforcers. They want the world's general balance maintained, because the more control their antagonists gain, the less footing and bargaining power they have. Their morality and their interest point the same way — not hypocrisy, but the structure of a carry-trade balancer: you genuinely believe in the open system because the open system is what makes you rich. Four fronts: out-manoeuvre the Drakteni (expansion changes the board); interdict the Prezish (predators on the flow they guarantee); relieve the Madekites when needed (same front as the Drakteni — defend the victim to check the aggressor); shield the Trusteki (protect the producer, protect the whole trade order).

Limits

WIP → Their reach is not infinite. They oppose all destabilisation in principle but must triage. Ossensteins: rarely even recognised — you cannot oppose a hand you cannot see, and their invisibility is their immunity. (The irony: the culture whose entire purpose is stopping board-owners is blind to the faction that already won.) Cailendroffs: currently self-contained — a threat in potential, not in motion, so no expenditure is warranted yet; but the Cailendroffs are actively recruiting toward a crusade, so the non-action is provisional. False Prophet: a spiritual threat, headed off by the Lenavorites — the church's front, not the wardens'. Implicit division of labour: the Lenavorite administration polices belief, the Voldrastel police the routes.

Pragmatism

WIP → They hold the Cailendroff Edict a fraud and would take the pretender's success over his failure. A unified Draggath Wastes is an objective good to a culture that thrives on trade and unification: peace ends the perpetual civil war, opens the northeast to routes, and creates one negotiable partner instead of a thousand warbands. They are not rooting for the Cailendroffs — they would settle for them. Legitimacy is the church's concern; the Voldrastel care about the outcome. They would crown A liar to close A wound.

Relations

Lenavorites — **protects** — The monolith is good for tolls — a stable superpower means taxable traffic.

Vorghith — **rival of** — Busy managing the chaos of the Vorghith.

Drakteni — **rival of** — Busy managing the expansion of the Drakteni.

Madekites — **protects** — Protector and protected — the Reach fortified into mutual defence.

Cailendroffs — **wary of them** — Feeble in a direct fight — deterred by the wardens.

Prezish — **rival of them** — The trade routes — predator vs protector.

Holdings

The Twelfth Reach.

The Faith, And Its Breaking

Lenavorites

Pure · Piety · Lenaveron

Government	Ecclesiocracy (papacy)
Authority	Divine mandate
Sacred	The Tetramorph
Organisation	Order
Economy	Tithe, alms
Kinship	The Order
Identity	You give the self up
Succession	Chosen vessel
Change	Past (tradition)
War doctrine	Zealot, crusade
Taboo	Naming the self / pride
Defined against	The faithless
Naming	St. [name] the [Order-adj]
Monuments	Papal Palace, Inquisitorial Palace

In the corner to the far east lie the Tombs of the Old Gods: vast ancient ruins of gothic basilicas and beautiful monuments to gods whose names have long been forgotten. From that cultural hearth these people dispersed — north into the Lost Woods, south into the deeper tundra to find Fair Whitewood, west across the Strait of Sorrow, or into the mountains, where the first record ever set down in all of Vaelohk was its name: Lenaveron. The Lenavorites are a self-flagellating, unforgiving people, eager to regain their lost devotion, seeking piety through any means. Tithe. Spread the gospel. Offer yourself as a missionary, or a martyr. And most importantly: record it. From the Lenavorites came a large papal institution of administration. The Inquisition of Ollanenor taught the way of life and assigned your role in it by assigning your name according to a saint, forgoing all prior sense of self.

Internal conflict

WIP → Low, and doctrinal. Mostly cooperative — like Catholics vs other Christians: real debate on smaller issues, general agreement, everyone rowing in the same direction. No one refuses to administrate or perform their role; the machine runs. The disagreements are over characterisation and priority within the Tetramorph — which face to weight, how a given god should be understood. Not schism: inflection. And these debates are the seed vocabulary of every future schism — a characterisation dispute held quietly inside orthodoxy for centuries is the fault line a real break eventually cracks along. The Belvareth are one that already left: they did not reject the church, they over-weighted wrath until they were a distinct order. The internal debate is the schism that has not happened yet.

Relations

Astravantheliad — depends on — The archive is the knowledge-state's foundation — a dependency, not a rivalry.

Belvareth — reveres — The guardians of the pilgrimage sites — keepers of the last relics.

Ossensteins — no relation with — No record - the record-keepers have never entered the Ossensteins into the ledger.

Ithiss — seeks to convert — The Inquisition seeks to leash the anarchy through religion.

Kraghs — conditional toward them — The honest ledger — victors want it kept, the beaten want it burned.

Trusteki — mixed with them — The Tithe against the papal contract — the same hand taxes and buys.

Voldrastel — protects them — The monolith is good for tolls — a stable superpower means taxable traffic.

Shassolin — preys on them — The false faith feeds on the true one — preying on the tithed poor.

Cailendroffs — resents them — The ledger falsifies the bloodline — a record they need buried.

Holdings

Lenaveron, Tombs of the Old Gods.

Madekites

Pair · Piety / Industry · Fair Whitewood

Government	A builders' ecclesiocracy — a guild of sacred masons under the church
Authority	Divine mandate + competence — the master-builder is holy
Sacred	The God of Gods + the work — building as worship, suffering as devotion
Organisation	Sacred Craft-Order (mason-monks)
Economy	Tithe + production — cathedral-building funded by faith and labor
Kinship	The order + the bloodline of craft (technique passed down within the faith)
Identity	You give the self up to the Work and you use your inheritance to further it
Succession	Chosen vessel via merit — the anointed master mason
Change	Past — recover the Lost technology of the Great Basilica
War doctrine	Defensive/siege engineering — fortress-cathedrals
Taboo	Waste + pride (a flawed or vain structure is sin)
Defined against	The wasteful and the faithless
Naming	St. [name] the [Craft-Order] [numeral]
Monuments	Office of Works, Papal Palace

Other pious fled into the frozen forest of Fair Whitewood, rich with tundra and forestry, during the fall of the old gods. They sought to redeem themselves, labouring to prove their devotion, suffering as a form of worship — all of it serving to reconstruct the wonders of the old gods, seeking perfection from stone and the ancient techniques used to raise cathedrals and citadels that insulate them from all foreign influence, reach, and affront. They build defence from devotion, in the desolate frozen tundra, chasing a vain perfection.

Relations

Voldrastel — protects — Protector and protected — the Reach fortified into mutual defence.

Trusteki — supplies — Most of the masonry skill and supply for the Trusteki.

Astravantheliad — ally them — Shared hunger for lost technology — the Basilica's secrets.

Drakteni — enemy of them — What building is for — conquest vs devotion.

Holdings

Fair Whitewood.

Belvareth

Pair · Piety / Prowess · Lost Woods

Government	Militant ecclesiocracy — a warrior-church / theocratic military order
Authority	Divine mandate proven by force
Sacred	Melvanar (Wrath), served through the sword — faith as holy violence. They worshipped wrath before Melvanar had a written name
Organisation	Militant Order / warrior-monks
Economy	Tithe + plunder (spoils of the crusade)
Kinship	The Militant Order of the Knight's Templar
Identity	You give the self up to the war for God
Succession	Chosen by output in battle
Change	Past/tradition — the sacred woods must never change
War doctrine	Zealot-crusade + tactical defense of the treeline
Taboo	Retreat and doubt (cowardice = faithlessness)
Defined against	The faithless-and-the-barbarian (the northern Kraghs are both)
Naming	St. [name] the [Order] — martial saint-names
Monuments	Preceptory of the Knight's Templar

South of the Draggath Wastes lie the Bleak Highlands, rough terrain suitable for smaller warbands who pledge fealty to larger ones. The most determined Kraghs, who sought glory and rich land, marched south to the Wheat Fields — a place once known for its fertile soil, now a perpetual battlefield in an attempt to lay claim to the Lost Woods, which are fervently protected by the Belvareth, the Order of the Preceptory of Melvanar. The Lost Woods are hallowed ground to those who are pious, and the Belvareth were formed by the most devout of the old gods and the Kraghs who sought a new way of life. Together they pair, in order to train in body and spirit and defend this sacred site from all outsiders of any kind.

Doctrine

WIP → Defensive crusade. Isolationist by conviction, devastating only at home. The Belvareth love a defensive fight and fight almost nowhere else: the Lost Woods - the one land the Great Fracture never touched - is their ground, and the killing comes to them, as pilgrims and Lenavorite missions walk in and are reduced. They do not march; they receive.

Limits

WIP → No power projection. Expansion into Lenaveron is unfounded and sacrilegious - one does not conquer the faith one broke from. They could not endure a campaign into the Bleak Highlands, and have no capacity for the Sea of Damnation. A wall, not a spear.

Relations

Lenavorites — preys on — The offering — the missions sent to them are cut down and given to Melvanar.

Kraghs — holds in contempt — Blasphemers and savages.

Holdings

Lost Woods, Wheat Fields.

The Pincer of Dead Waters

WIP → Every northern assault on the Wheat Fields had broken on the Lost Woods treeline. A Prowess warlord took the minimum slice of Industry to raise a single disposable shipyard on the then-unnamed northern bay. Double-move: the main host drove south from the north (the expected assault, drawing defenders to the treeline) while the shipyard-born flotilla landed on their flank/rear from the water. The most successful assault on the Lost Woods to date. The bay was named Dead Waters for what came out of it. 'Most successful assault' is the attacker's framing; the Lost Woods crusaders name the day a massacre / a drowning. The highlanders, who agreed to join the Mason-King's mercenary company in exchange for his services. Payment in men, not coin — Karalius came out of the deal with a fleet and an army. The warlord did not have a stroke of genius; he had a budget. Every prior assault on the Wheat Fields broke on the treeline because nobody was willing to pay Karalius' number. The one who finally was, won. The only defeat ever recorded of the Belvareth. They gave ground in the Wheat Fields for the first time that day — on ground that is never paved because it is hallowed. For an order whose taboo is retreat and doubt, this is not a battle loss but a theological event: the standard failed the test, and every warlord ever turned back there learned it could be done. Worse, the tactic mirrored them — a two-pronged attack against an order whose entire discipline is holding two halves in balance. 156 years later the alministralum's edges began to break.

Shassolin

Pair · Cunning / Piety · Shallow Mire / Quiet Hollow

Government	A missionary hierarchy fronting as a church
Authority	Divine mandate (claimed) + leverage (real)
Sacred	The False Prophet — publicly the God of Gods, privately the wealth generated from it
Organisation	Missionary order that is really a syndicate cell
Economy	Tithe + extraction — fleece the faithful
Kinship	The order over hidden brotherhood (CxPxI)
Identity	You give the self up to convince others to join
Succession	Chosen vessel (claimed) / intrigue (real)
Change	Tradition as cover — the con relies on looking ancient
War doctrine	Martyrdom + sabotage — poorly armed converts + quiet coercion
Taboo	Being exposed as false (fusion of 'being known' + 'pride/self')
Defined against	The honest and (privately) the truly faithful they prey on
Naming	St. [name] the [Order] as the public face
Monuments	Senate Hall, Inquisitorial Palace

Others moved east out of the Dreadwood, finding marsh and pious people seeking refuge, whose journey named the Strait of Sorrow. The Shassolin found religion in its despondency. They formed a new order — one of a new prophet, the Last Prophet, capable of speaking to the God of Gods himself, knowing and uttering its name, Esselantheum, and carrying messages directly to him. Missionary work is perpetual, seeking more to convert, to tithe, and to offer indulgences for their lack of faith. Unfortunately, it never seems to be enough.

Relations

Lenavorites — preys on — The false faith feeds on the true one — preying on the tithed poor.

Itihiss — seeks to convert — The false faith reaches for the same leash - control through religion.

Astravantheliad — tolerates them — Tolerated — sovereignty respected even for the false faith.

Cailendroffs — rival of them — Competition in the game of intellectual warfare.

Ossensteins — controls them — Rumoured to manage the Shassolin's trade and religion.

Holdings

Shallow Mire / Quiet Hollow, Strait of Sorrow.

The War That Did Not End

Kraghs

Pure · Prowess · Draggath Wastes / Bleak Highlands

Government	Kratocracy
Authority	Force / victory
Sacred	War itself (deified) — combat is their god, glory-or-death is the sacrament
Organisation	Warband
Economy	Plunder, tribute
Kinship	The band (allegiance)
Identity	You are who you fight for
Succession	Strongest takes
Change	Present (glory-now)
War doctrine	Open force / shock and tactical (maneuver, discipline)
Taboo	Retreat / cowardice
Defined against	The weak
Naming	[name] of the [Warband]
Monuments	Royal Pavilion, Ministry of Military Strategy

In the Draggath Wastes there once stood an empire whose monarch reigned as the longest and largest dynasty in all of Vaelohk. Then a great famine swept Draggath, and a great fracturing occurred, and the empire turned into civil war — each city-state and warband fighting over shrinking tillable, fertile soil. From that civil war arose the Kraghs, a people of prowess. They rule as iron-fisted leaders, treasuring martial training and strength above all else, settling disputes by battle, eager to prove themselves against their neighbouring counterparts. Plunder and vassals lie waiting for those who succeed in the ruins of the Draggath Wastes — an ancient empire's remains scattered across desolate, sandy soil.

Warbands

WIP → Since Pravak, Kragh warbands sit on a spectrum from individual skill to positional strategy. A warband's place on it is advertised — a recruiting pitch to unpledged young men choosing where to make their mark. The strategy-end warbands train almost purely in military strategy over personal prowess. Battlefield cunning is honoured; the knife in the dark is beneath them.

Relations

Lenavorites — **conditional toward** — The honest ledger — victors want it kept, the beaten want it burned.

Belvareth — **reveres** — The ancient warriors of Cailen — strongest fighters, who harness the old gods.

Trusteki — **depends on** — They cannot feed or move themselves - reliant on Trusteki supply lines.

Sarkopekt — **no relation with them** — No relation — beneath them, and no profit either way.

Drakteni — enemy of them — Hermit's Row — the Drakteni hold the narrows, the Kraghs try to break it.

Vorghith — enemy of them — Supply lines, and the impossibility of telling friend from enemy.

Holdings

Draggath Wastes, Bleak Highlands, Glen of Pravak, Cravencroft.

The Pincer of Dead Waters

WIP → Every northern assault on the Wheat Fields had broken on the Lost Woods treeline. A Prowess warlord took the minimum slice of Industry to raise a single disposable shipyard on the then-unnamed northern bay. Double-move: the main host drove south from the north (the expected assault, drawing defenders to the treeline) while the shipyard-born flotilla landed on their flank/rear from the water. The most successful assault on the Lost Woods to date. The bay was named Dead Waters for what came out of it. 'Most successful assault' is the attacker's framing; the Lost Woods crusaders name the day a massacre / a drowning. The highlanders, who agreed to join the Mason-King's mercenary company in exchange for his services. Payment in men, not coin — Karalius came out of the deal with a fleet and an army. The warlord did not have a stroke of genius; he had a budget. Every prior assault on the Wheat Fields broke on the treeline because nobody was willing to pay Karalius' number. The one who finally was, won. The only defeat ever recorded of the Belvareth. They gave ground in the Wheat Fields for the first time that day — on ground that is never paved because it is hallowed. For an order whose taboo is retreat and doubt, this is not a battle loss but a theological event: the standard failed the test, and every warlord ever turned back there learned it could be done. Worse, the tactic mirrored them — a two-pronged attack against an order whose entire discipline is holding two halves in balance. 156 years later the alministralum's edges began to break.

Vogen

WIP → A Vorghith general. He led a warband to control everything up to the Bleak Highlands — the northern limit of their expansion — and went no further. Assassinating his opponents by public execution. Vogen's Gallows is named for the method, and the site has carried his name for some three thousand years since. Public execution is not battlefield glory: a Kragh kills you in open combat for honour, and Vogen hangs you in the square so that everyone watches.

Vorghith

Pair · Prowess / Cunning · Vogen's Gallows (enclave)

Government	Warlord dictatorship by fear & reputation
Authority	Force applied through terror — rule by strangulation
Sacred	Chaos and Disruption, not glory
Organisation	Warband run like a Syndicate
Economy	Plunder + extraction/racket — economic warfare is the economy
Kinship	The band + hidden cells
Identity	You are what you've done — your raids, your kills
Succession	Strongest takes or out-schemes
Change	Opportunistic
War doctrine	Guerrilla, ambush, attrition, economic strangulation; evade decisive battle
Taboo	Fighting head-on (evasion is doctrine, not cowardice — inverts Prowess retreat-taboo)
Defined against	The weak and the honest
Naming	[name] of the [Warband] or earned byname — Vogen's people carry grim bynames
Monuments	Outrider Intercept Post, Royal Pavilion

Many Ithiss of the Dreadwood, shipwrecked or imprisoned, found venture in a world where fighting in the open was expected — glory prioritised. From the shadows the Vorghith rose the night, attacking the Kraghs in their sleep and behind their front lines, causing fear and disrupting the supply lines of those who cross them. The Kraghs, never knowing friend from foe, retreated from the prison fortress and bay. From there a wave of terror spread: raiding settlements in the night, burning crops and granaries, razing infrastructure, and capturing neighbouring leaders to execute them in the prison's square — Vogen's Gallows. The Vorghith refuse a fair fight and evade any sustained skirmish, always retreating into the towns they will strike that night.

Relations

Kraghs — enemy of — Supply lines, and the impossibility of telling friend from enemy.

Trusteki — preys on — Stolen ships against the trade routes - the sea raid on the market's lifelines.

Voldrastel — preys on — Coastlines and routes raided - the chaos the wardens exist to contain.

Astravantheliad — preys on — The only ones daring - or stupid enough - to commandeer the Prezish or raid the Vaelohk coast.

Drakteni — preys on — Scylla - a handful of ships vanish as the cost of expansion.

Sarkopekt — enemy of them — The contract enemy — hired to drive them out.

Holdings

Vogen's Gallows.

Vogen

WIP → A Vorghith general. He led a warband to control everything up to the Bleak Highlands — the northern limit of their expansion — and went no further. Assassinating his opponents by public execution. Vogen's Gallows is named for the method, and the site has carried his name for some three thousand years since. Public execution is not battlefield glory: a Kragh kills you in open combat for honour, and Vogen hangs you in the square so that everyone watches.

Drakteni

Pair · Prowess / Industry · Heathport / Drakenheart

Government	Martial republic / a professional officer-state
Authority	Competence + force — command earned by skill and rank
Sacred	War + the work — the engineered victory
Organisation	Craft-warband (a professional standing army with an engineering corps)
Economy	Production + tribute — they build the war machine and take by it
Kinship	Regiments served through bloodline
Identity	You are your training and your record
Succession	Merit/rank — promotion through the professional hierarchy
Change	Future/progress in the art of war — better siege, better arms
War doctrine	Tech, logistics, siege — the best-equipped, disciplined siege specialists
Taboo	Unpreparedness + cowardice — an ill-supplied or broken line is shameful
Defined against	The wasteful and the amateurish, the unequipped
Naming	[name] [craft-surname] [numeral] — surnames of war-trades (Gunner, Sapper)
Monuments	Advanced Blast Furnace, Ministry of Military Strategy

West of the Wastes, Trusteki who had run from the disease-ridden peninsula of Blighthold found Kraghs escaping the war-torn desolation of the wasteland behind them. Together they settled a small continent rich with mines, erecting siege works and blast furnaces to construct equipment of war, eager to expand their territory. The youngest of cultures, these people focused — erecting a martial hierarchy, building armaments, siege craft and professional soldiery into a way of life. The expansion of their territory grew into their greatest edict, laying campaigns against the Kraghs in Hermit's Row and besieging the Madekites in the frozen, desolate cathedral fortresses of Fair Whitewood.

Relations

Sarkopekt — ally — Specialised mercenaries for advanced campaigns and strategic operations.

Astravantheliad — ally — Technology for political immunity — quid pro quo, up to a point.

Madekites — enemy of — What building is for — conquest vs devotion.

Kraghs — enemy of — Hermit's Row — the Drakteni hold the narrows, the Kraghs try to break it.

Voldrastel — rival of them — Busy managing the expansion of the Drakteni.

Vorghith — preys on them — Scylla - a handful of ships vanish as the cost of expansion.

Holdings

Heathport, Drakenheart, Hermit's Row.

Cailendroffs

Triple · Piety / Prowess / Cunning · Cailendroff Isles

Government	Court-in-exile of a claimed monarch — sacred kingship
Authority	Bloodright (Prowess) + divine mandate (Piety) — both possibly fabricated (Cunning)
Sacred	The God of Gods — the pretender as divinely anointed; the war as crusade
Organisation	A royalist warband-order around the prince
Economy	Tribute + tithe + covert financing by handlers
Kinship	The claimed royal bloodline + loyal band + the order
Identity	You serve the true king / you give the self up to the cause
Succession	Bloodright — the sacred royal line (the whole legitimacy question)
Change	Past — restoration; reverse the Great Fracture of Draggath
War doctrine	Crusade-reconquest + the schemers' plots
Taboo	Doubting the prince's legitimacy (retreat + heresy + exposure all in one)
Defined against	The usurpers / all who deny the true anointed king
Naming	Royal names + war-bynames that have demonstrated your allegiance to the true crown; the prince is the only St. Name. 'the True King of Draggath over the water'
Monuments	Imperial Palace, Royal Pavilion

Close by in the isles, the Cailendroffs have been exiled since the Great Fracture, over four thousand years ago, long scheming the return of their monarch to the Draggath throne — whom they believe is the last surviving bloodline of the oldest dynasty. The Cailendroffs believe they are direct descendants of the Warrior-Prophet Cailen, one of the old gods, who chose Draggath as Emperor. These people believe they are the last true way to unite the Kraghs, and are preparing their armies for crusade, converting as many as they can to reinstate the Scion of Draggath over the Water.

Relations

Lenavorites — **resents** — The ledger falsifies the bloodline — a record they need buried.

Astravantheliad — **rival of** — Competition in the game of intellectual warfare.

Shassolin — **rival of** — Competition in the game of intellectual warfare.

Sarkopekt — **wary of** — Feeble in a real conflict — avoided, not fought.

Voldrastel — **wary of** — Feeble in a direct fight — deterred by the wardens.

Holdings

Cailendroff Isles.

Sarkopekt

Triple · Cunning / Industry / Prowess · Free-company node network, no homeland: ne Vaelohk, Ivory Isle, Bleak Highlands, Dead Waters, Wharf of St. Brannoch, Bay of Lost Hope, Quiet Hollow, Cailendroff Isle

Government	Militarized corporate-oligarchy — an amoral war-industrial board
Authority	Force + leverage + competence — the best-armed and best-connected rule
Sacred	War + the work + the game — victory-at-any-cost, sold and waged
Organisation	Arms-syndicate with a professional army
Economy	Arms production + racket + plunder — make weapons, sell them, use them
Kinship	Weaponsmith dynasties + syndicate
Identity	You are what you've built and how you've used it
Succession	Merit + intrigue + strength — the sharpest operator
Change	Future — every edge, every new weapon and tactic
War doctrine	Hyper-strategy, win-at-all-costs, any tactic for an edge; well-equipped
Taboo	Losing an edge / being outbid / being outgunned
Defined against	The weak, the honest, and the wasteful (everyone soft or naive)
Naming	[earned combat byname] [arms-surname] [numeral]
Monuments	Outrider Intercept Post, Ministry of Military Strategy

Off the coast of Lenaveron, the Wharf of St. Brannoch operates as a natural sanctuary, allowing a merchant class of city-states, warbands, and travelling nomads to work as freelancers and arms-dealers, with small nodes in every corner of the world — from the Bay of Lost Hope to the shores of the Bleak Highlands. These people are known as the Sarkopekt. Run by merchant kings and border princes, striking deals of protection, a supply of arms, or hired freelancers as a standing army, living in the moral ambiguities of others' objectives and desires, for a steep price. These people will tear wealth from flesh, given the chance.

Relations

Drakteni — **ally** — Specialised mercenaries for advanced campaigns and strategic operations.

Prezish — **ally** — The arms market — Prezish supply lines and brokered deals.

Vorghith — **enemy of** — The contract enemy — hired to drive them out.

Kraghs — **no relation with** — No relation — beneath them, and no profit either way.

Trusteki — **ally** — Lumber for safe passage - trade at the Bay of Lost Hope.

Cailendroffs — **wary of them** — Feeble in a real conflict — avoided, not fought.

Holdings

Ivory Isle, Dead Waters, Bay of Lost Hope, Wharf of St. Brannoch.

The Pincer of Dead Waters

WIP → Every northern assault on the Wheat Fields had broken on the Lost Woods treeline. A Prowess warlord took the minimum slice of Industry to raise a single disposable shipyard on the then-unnamed northern bay. Double-move: the main host drove south from the north (the expected assault, drawing defenders to the treeline) while the shipyard-born flotilla landed on their flank/rear from the water. The most successful assault on the Lost Woods to date. The bay was named Dead Waters for what came out of it. 'Most successful assault' is the attacker's framing; the Lost Woods crusaders name the day a massacre / a drowning. The highlanders, who agreed to join the Mason-King's mercenary company in exchange for his services. Payment in men, not coin — Karalius came out of the deal with a fleet and an army. The warlord did not have a stroke of genius; he had a budget. Every prior assault on the Wheat Fields broke on the treeline because nobody was willing to pay Karalius' number. The one who finally was, won. The only defeat ever recorded of the Belvareth. They gave ground in the Wheat Fields for the first time that day — on ground that is never paved because it is hallowed. For an order whose taboo is retreat and doubt, this is not a battle loss but a theological event: the standard failed the test, and every warlord ever turned back there learned it could be done. Worse, the tactic mirrored them — a two-pronged attack against an order whose entire discipline is holding two halves in balance. 156 years later the alministralum's edges began to break.

Mason-King Karalius II

WIP → Sarkopekt. Famous shipwright and builder of masonry citadels, seated at Ivory Isle. His wealth is recognized — not self-styled, not contested; the title is acknowledged because the money is undeniable. The expensive solution that always works. You do not hire Karalius because he is clever; you hire him because you have run out of cheaper options and you need the thing to actually happen. The price is the price, and the wall stands, and the ship floats. Ii implies a Karalius I — an anomaly in a culture whose succession is merit, intrigue, and strength. Likely the Industry craft-lineage numeral worn as a crown: a workshop convention repurposed as royal succession. He is not complicit; he is infrastructure. Whatever you use him for is on you. The Voldrastel refuse to deal with him on principle; the Prezish keep his terms on file.

The Centre

Astravantheliad

Center · Piety / Prowess / Cunning / Industry · Vaelohk (the center island)

Government	Technocracy — expertise is the currency of proximity; courtiers contest each other through information and expertise to climb toward the Duke
Authority	Access — whoever is nearest the throne; positional
Sacred	Influence / proximity to power through competitive proofs & application of expertise that result positively on the Astravantheliad
Organisation	The court / courtiers, a hierarchy
Economy	Rents, patronage, brokerage — they produce nothing; they broker
Kinship	Alliance networks / who owes whom
Identity	You are your proximity to power
Succession	Positioning — outlast and outmaneuver at court
Change	Whatever preserves access — the ultimate pragmatists
War doctrine	None of their own — they deploy others using their logistical and strategic knowledge (incl. Populism as a tool)
Taboo	Irrelevance / distance from power / to be indebted to another
Defined against	The provincial (those with convictions but no access)
Naming	[Court-standing] [name] of [Academic Hall]; the hyper-intellectual demonym performs their vanity
Monuments	Stadium Generale, Senate Hall, Aristocratic Court

In the centre lies a large isle, Vaelohk, home to those who travelled through the Sea of Drakes, survived the doldrums of the Lonely Sea, and saw miracles on the Sea of Miracles. From there the Astravantheliad rose, embracing all knowledge, generalising in all works and walks of life, continuously researching and seeking mastery in life. With this came great influence, which was harnessed by the Duke — whose authority is granted by the Astravantheliad as a neutral arbiter to all cultures.

The fund

WIP → One shared account. Complete egalitarians who are also, all of them, wealthy — the isle operates as a single pooled endowment. If you need money you withdraw; if you do not, you put in. This is not communal idealism, it is a liquidity pool, and it does three things. Nobody accumulates, so nobody can be leveraged — their taboo about being indebted to another is enforced by the structure rather than by virtue. The fund is always deployable, because idle money returns to it, which is what lets an entire isle underwrite sixty-year research projects. And there is no such thing as an Astravantheliad debt crisis, a ruined family, or a fortune to seize: an invader takes an island, not a treasury. Wealth is Flat, so it cannot be the currency of status — which leaves expertise as the only differentiator, and is why the technocracy's meritocracy holds.

Their army

WIP → Mediocre and decently equipped. Every citizen carries basic military training as part of the four-domain baseline, so they field a competent militia: everyone has had the drill, the kit is good, nobody is a specialist.

Enough to hold their own island and be a real cost to invade; nowhere near enough to project force or take ground from people who do that professionally. That threshold is exactly why the office exists — a defenceless centre would be a prize and the Duke would be somebody's puppet within a generation, while a centre that could compel would arbitrate at swordpoint like everyone else. The office is the instrument of A people who can defend but cannot compel. Contrast the Drakteni: the same Industry capacity for equipment, opposite application — they forge the advantage and take ground with it; the centre equips everyone adequately and takes ground from no one. The kit is insurance, not a plan.

Governance

WIP → An academically led technocracy focused on myopic, specific problems, each citizen dedicating a whole life to one pursuit. Those with the best outcomes and greatest products are voted into the technocratic senate that takes court with the Duke, representing the most influential members of Vaelohk.

Diplomacy

WIP → The primary delegates other cultures interact with during envoys and diplomatic negotiation. Even when not participating, they are at the center of influence. Knowledge is indeed power.

Relations

Lenavorites — **depends on** — The archive is the knowledge-state's foundation — a dependency, not a rivalry.

Prezish — **patron of** — The rare-goods pipeline — the collector at the clean end of a dirty chain.

Shassolin — **tolerates** — Tolerated — sovereignty respected even for the false faith.

Cailendroffs — **tolerates** — Tolerated — sovereignty respected even for the false bloodline.

Ossensteins — **denies** — Officially they aren't real — the state denies the Ossensteins exist.

Madekites — **ally** — Shared hunger for lost technology — the Basilica's secrets.

Drakteni — **ally them** — Technology for political immunity — quid pro quo, up to a point.

Vorghith — **preys on them** — The only ones daring - or stupid enough - to commandeer the Prezish or raid the Vaelohk coast.

Holdings

Vaelohk.

Ossensteins

Triple · Cunning / Piety / Industry · Prophet's Landing

Government	A financier-cartel running a false church — puppet-master oligarchy
Authority	Money + leverage + claimed divine mandate
Sacred	The False Prophet — the industrialized con of the God of Gods
Organisation	Syndicate that owns a manufactured religion
Economy	Industrialized extraction — the racket as a vertically-integrated enterprise
Kinship	Financier bloodlines + hidden syndicate + the front-order
Identity	You are invisible
Succession	Machiavellian intrigue — inherit control and retain power at all costs
Change	Opportunistic + progress — scale and optimize the con
War doctrine	Sabotage — hire and undermine, rarely fight openly
Taboo	Waste + exposure — an unprofitable or discovered scheme is failure
Defined against	The honest, the wasteful, and the truly faithful
Naming	Hidden and mysterious faction, unknown
Monuments	Inquisitorial Palace, Office of Works, Aristocratic Court

In the shadows of every important Academic Hall, administrative building, and public forum, the Ossensteins are rumoured to exist. It is believed they own more than half the wealth in all of Vaelohk, and that they are the handlers of the False Prophet — creating disasters and catastrophes to profit and to influence.

Relations

Prezish — controls — Rumoured to manage the Prezish trade and brokering.

Shassolin — controls — Rumoured to manage the Shassolin's trade and religion.

Lenavorites — no relation with them — No record - the record-keepers have never entered the Ossensteins into the ledger.

Astravantheliad — denies them — Officially they aren't real — the state denies the Ossensteins exist.

Holdings

Prophet's Landing.